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KF Introduction to NHG

Chapter 11: *Resignation*¹

This is our last *Neurosis and Human Growth* study session. Dr. Horney has uncovered for us the basic problem of neurosis, which affects everything we think, feel, and do, and you might be asking yourself, “What do I do now? How can I grow out of neurosis and start living a more productive, healthier, happier life? How can I align my life with God’s plans and purposes?” Karis Fellowships is a training program that has helped many people redirect their lives away from pride, fear, conflict, and strain. If you want to grow into your potential in Christ, you may wish to train with a community of believers who are working to do just that!

In chapter 11, Dr. Horney describes the neurotic solution of resignation. The Bible gives us several examples of this neurotic type. In the book of First Samuel, we are introduced to the high priest, Eli. When Eli sees Hannah fervently praying in the temple, he reacts to her strong feelings with criticism and irritation. Perhaps he saw in her a passion for God that he knew did not exist within himself. Her strong feelings scared him, but God responded to Hannah’s faith by granting her request. Hannah’s active trust is a strong contrast to Eli’s passivity. Eli knew that his sons, who were priests, were behaving in a reprehensible way, but he made no effort to correct or restrain them, and God rebuked him for his inaction. Eli never asked God how to deal with this situation because he didn’t want to know. Knowing might bring with it obligations, and obligation is something the resigned neurotic wants to avoid at all costs. In the end, Eli died from his own inertia (1 Sam. 4:18).

Isaac, the father of Esau and Jacob, also took refuge in resignation. He could not see the turmoil going on around him because he did not want to see it. He refused to take responsibility for his family’s conflicts and was unwilling to help those around him find solutions. By habitually refusing to engage with his own life, he obligated others to take on his responsibilities. Isaac was only interested in maintaining his own comfortable routines and remaining free from imposition. It is, therefore, not surprising that his wife learned to act on her own initiative. She knew that her husband could only be relied upon to do nothing.

Isaac passed his resigned attitude and habits on to his eldest son, Esau. Even though Esau had a flash of remorse over the results of his decision to sell his birthright, prosperity allowed him to escape the immediate consequences of his choices. He eventually drifted back into non-engagement. When we read about Esau, we never see him make any effort to grow into a man whom God could trust. Even his grudge against his brother Jacob became an imposition that required too much effort to sustain. He eventually invited Jacob back into a jolly, generous relationship that did not require any growth or personal development. Jacob, however, was wise enough to see that Esau’s unwillingness to actively engage with God made his brother untrustworthy.

When Jesus was in the wilderness, the devil tempted Him with the solution of resignation, saying, “Turn these stones into bread” — in other words, “Don’t make life harder than it need be. Look after number one and you will be completely free to do what you like. If you don’t depend on anyone, they won’t depend on you.” He invited Jesus to take the easy way out by enticing Him to reject the obligations and

¹ Karen Horney, *Neurosis and Human Growth* (New York: Norton, 1991).

difficulties of His mission and, instead, to pursue autonomous freedom. Many resigned people work hard to gain financial freedom or plod away at careers that promise a long and comfortable retirement. They are sustained by the illusion that they can live a life of complete freedom without ever having to change. Many people in our modern culture are resigned and appear to be undisturbed by the complex problems that Dr. Horney describes. However, underneath their placid exterior, they are driven by chronic anxiety, which often explodes into unreasonable reactions and hostility. Any form of imposition, whether from others or from within themselves, feels like a threat.

The ability of healthy resigned types to stand immovable and pursue their own path can, however, support God's purposes and glory. Their commitment to self-preservation and autonomy demonstrates to other types what healthy boundaries look like. These boundaries help us guard the real self against our neurotic tendency to dissipate resources. Supported by the dynamics of a trustworthy community and a growing connection with God, resigned types can allow their defensive walls to be transformed into healthy, functioning boundaries that will allow them to fearlessly contribute their substantial gifts to the world.

KF Facilitator Guide

Chapter 11: *Resignation*¹

0:00 Weekly/0:00 Weekend Intensive (WI)

Lead Facilitator starts the recording by pressing *9.

“Welcome everyone to the session 11 of the KF *Neurosis and Human Growth* book study. We will begin by reading the Introduction to this chapter.”

Support Facilitator reads the Introduction.

Lead Facilitator: “Thank you. Let’s go to Presenting. When you give us your name and location, you might also share something you are hoping for. I will begin.”

“My name is _____. I am calling from _____ and I am hoping _____.”

- Facilitators open the [NHG Spreadsheet](#) to record attendance and homework completion.
- Each facilitator makes a list of the names of students as they present.
- Lead facilitator prepares group divisions while students present.
- Lead facilitator assigns groups and says, “To leave the main group, press *3 and then, when prompted, enter your group number. To return to the main group, press *3*.”
- Each facilitator asks, “Is there anyone who has not filled out their reading guide?”
- Each facilitator assigns the first 10 questions to two students, 5 questions each. Continue to answer the questions in sets of 10, assigning 5 questions per student in rotation.

Questions 29 and 30 are open questions.

0:10/0:10 WI

1. The third major solution of the internal conflict consists of what? (259.1)

Withdrawing from the inner battlefield and declaring oneself uninterested.

2. Why does Dr. Horney call this solution “resignation”? (259.1)

Because this type resigns from active living.

3. Resigned people often pass for what? (259.1)

Normal.

Our society’s sense of what is healthy is generally blunted. Most of us are neurotic to some degree and do not have a clear sense of what healthy looks like. Neurotics tend to want to impose conformity on themselves and others because they are afraid to allow variety. Variety requires flexibility, and neurotics cannot afford to be flexible; their supporting structure is necessarily rigid. Healthy people are flexible. They explore, discover their own gifts and potential, and help others to discover theirs.

Resigned people want to stay off the radar, so unless they are the rebellious type, they don’t rock too many boats. Societies like conformity, so the resigned solution may feel more comfortable for everyone.

4. For this neurotic solution, what does resignation imply? (260.2)

Settling for a peace which is merely an absence of conflict.

Settling for less instead of reaching for higher goals; shrinking, restricting and curtailing life's growth.

These people give up the struggle rather than change who they are. For them, settling for less is preferable to staying in the battle. They don't want to work the muscles that will help them succeed in weak areas. They may be successful in some areas, but they don't want to change or adjust themselves to life's situations.

5. Describe the picture of resignation. (260.3)

Life at a constant low ebb without pain or friction but also without zest.

Resigned types forge a space around themselves, forcing others to accommodate or mold themselves around that space. They rely on the conventions of relationships rather than building relationships based on mutual growth and support. Building relationships requires change, and change is just too threatening.

6. What distinguishes the basic characteristics of resignation? (260.4)

An aura of restriction, of something that is avoided, that is not wanted or not done.

- They might spend a lot of time watching TV. Their whole life is like watching TV. They are not engaged.
- They often look to others (institutions, government, spouses, etc.) to take care of realities so that they can avoid the responsibilities of living in community, responsibilities which might stir up self-awareness.
- They are always looking for a safe corner of principles, truths, or beliefs that they can decide on once and for all, and then they stick to that corner when facing the world.
- When they have nailed down a 'truth', whether real or imagined, they can simply react to life based on that truth. They no longer need to explore, understand, or think. If they can preemptively nail down 330 degrees of 'truths', they have only 30 degrees to think about. They are terrified that if they have to consider more than that, they won't be able to cope. If they question one of their 'truths', they will have to question all of them. They live in deep and largely unconscious anxiety.

A student said: "The 'truths' become my boundaries. My back is protected."

7. What is the resigned type's ubiquitous and prominent attitude? (261.1)

Detachment—they are onlookers at others.

Resigned types can often make very astute observations but are not interested in changing themselves.

They spend a lot of energy discussing what is wrong with the world, but they never examine what is wrong with themselves except in a self-dismissive way that is humorous or without conviction and devoid of any intention of change. They are proud of their stuck position.

8. What does "being an onlooker" at oneself mean? (261.1)

Not actively participating in living and unconsciously refusing to do so.

Resigned people can choose busyness to avoid participating in active, personally engaged living.

9. What risk does this type avoid? (261.2)

The risk of seeing any of their conflicts.

One student said: “When life forces engage, it can be terrifying, like watching a movie which suddenly spills out of the screen and into your life. Then the need to escape is amplified. It requires a lot of courage to engage with it and stand.”

During one of our studies, our resigned expert actually zoned out during this chapter, stopped thinking, and disengaged. At first, he thought that he had zoned out because he felt overwhelmed, but after some thought he realized that he had disengaged from the meeting because he felt the threat of emerging awareness about his inner life.

Resigned types may fantasize about creating a space, a workshop, a job where no one would bother them. They dream of building a castle and pulling up the drawbridge.

0:15/0:15 WI

10. What characteristic of the resigned type is intimately connected with nonparticipation? (261.3)

The absence of any serious striving for achievement and the aversion to effort.

Resigned types may work hard to find that space where no one will bother them. They might seek financial freedom by building a business or earning a government retirement to provide regular income, but when they are financially free, they don't do anything with their life. They might run a successful blog, for example, but they are using the activity to divert their energy away from self-examination.

11. Concomitant with the aversion to effort, what is absent in the resigned person? (262.5)

There is an absence of goal-planning and direction, which may concern major and minor issues.

Resigned types can be very organized and scheduled, but the object of their schedule is to get things done so that they never have to think about it again. Feeling trapped by daily maintenance tasks imposes on their “freedom”. They want to “get things done” so that they can be free, but they cannot accept that there is always more to do, so they spend their lives trying to get things done rather than engaging with life.

Some resigned types will not organize their lives because living in confusion gives them a feeling of freedom. Even though the confusion is miserable, they are proud of their freedom from restrictions.

They engage in constant cruising, traveling, or wilderness trekking to escape themselves and community responsibilities.

12. What does “serenity” mean for this type? (263.1)

The absence of all trouble, irritations, and upsets. Whatever they hope for should come easily to them without pain or strain.

13. Who should present the clue that will solve everything? (263.1)

The analyst (therapist or group leader).

Resigned types expect magic from the therapist or from KF. They think that the therapist, this book study, or KF should “do” something to them. When nothing changes, they claim that the therapy

didn't work. They are unconscious of their resistance to any change and would not recognize any change in themselves even if it was evident to others.

14. What does this type always mind? (263.1)

The effort of changing.

It seems that only passing a threshold of serious pain, struggle, or adverse events will get their attention. It is in the suffering that they can see that their resigned solution is not working.

The facilitator might ask: "Is there a resigned type in the group? Would you say that suffering helped prompt you to join this book study or get into KF?"

15. What is the very essence of resignation? (263.2)

The restriction of wishes.

If a woman doesn't wish for a new house even though she has the capability to go out and buy one, she can avoid the change of moving. When she decides that it is time to shop for a house, she resists the change by suddenly feeling completely overwhelmed by her housing options. The confusion of "not knowing what she wants" makes her resist wishing at all.

16. What do resigned people believe it is better not to do? (263.2)

It is better not to wish or to expect anything.

Many things appear desirable in vague, idle ways, but fail to arouse a concrete wish or action.

Losing weight is desirable, but not enough to change a lifestyle. Resentment toward those who do change is easier than changing oneself.

17. What is the one wish that a resigned person does have? (264.1)

The wish of not being bothered.

18. What are the two outstanding neurotic claims of this type? (264.1)

- A. Life should be easy, painless, and effortless**
- B. To not be bothered**

Relationships are very challenging for resigned people. There is the desire for human interaction, but the resistance to being bothered or bothering someone else prevents the effort. It is difficult for this type to ask for help or receive help, or to be part of an inter-dependent community.

A resigned student said, "If I bother others, they will start bothering me."

It is hard for resigned people to feel guilt or take responsibility for what they are doing, and they think that their efforts to not bother anyone justify their detachment. They might argue, "I don't engage with you, so you should not try to engage with me. Engaging is a bother. See how I'm protecting you from bother by not engaging with you?"

One goal for the resigned type is to get to the place where they do not feel anything at all. It is taboo to have strong feelings. Feelings are bothersome.

19. What is the resigned person particularly anxious not to do? (264.2)

Not to get attached to anything to the extent of really needing it.

It is terrifying to even approach the possibility of needing something or someone.

0:30/0:30 WI

20. If the loss of someone or something would be painful, what do resigned people do? (264.2)

They tend to retract their feelings.

They can be interested and even enthusiastic in the NHG study, but suddenly drop out because it just doesn't interest them anymore. They retract the feelings that motivated them to join the study because they are now aware that the study has endangered the uneasy peace from chronic anxiety that they work so hard to maintain.

21. Even in lasting relationships, what must this type maintain? (265.3)

They must maintain their distance.

They often maintain distance by losing interest in the person or activity. They have already lost interest in God as a person and in themselves. They are afraid that God might want to be an active participant in their lives.

22. To what is the resigned type hypersensitive? (266.2)

They are hypersensitive to influence, pressure, coercion, or ties of any kind.

When others put pressure on resigned types, they take secret delight in resisting that pressure—and that can be maddening! They have highly developed evasion techniques.

One resigned person would not give a direct order to a waitress. Her asking for an order pushed the button that something was required of him. He delighted in resisting her pressure by a waffling vagueness.

23. How might this type express inward rebellion? (266.3)

They may consciously or unconsciously passively frustrate others by not responding or by forgetting.

They might use humor to divert people away from recognizing their untrustworthiness.

It is a taboo for resigned types to be clear and direct. They avoid commitment by giving vague responses.

Even someone tries to make an appointment with them, it can feel coercive, so they say they are not available simply to avoid feeling coerced. They can only feel comfortable when they are the ones who make the arrangement to meet.

They won't make promises because it might tie them down or bind them to something, even when they are making a commitment for their own well-being. If they do make a promise, their inward rebellion might cause them to not follow through.

If they can answer a request with "maybe," they can allow themselves to follow through because they feel free and don't have to resent the imposition.

KF training can feel like a terrific imposition on these people.

24. What do resigned people feel as a coercion? (266.4–267.1)

Any expectation that they should do something.

They are afraid that someone with stronger wishes might easily impose on them and push them into doing something that they don't want to do. Resigned people often marry the other neurotic types because the other types have strong feelings and are motivated about what they want.

Resigned parents might admire but also be afraid of their mastery children. When they feel threatened, they can shut their mastery children down and withdraw from the child so that their children cannot access them. It is very frustrating for these children, and rage builds up within the child. The parent is unable to help the child learn to manage anger because the parent refuses to manage or even acknowledge their own anger.

Resigned people just flop down and dare others to drag them.

Self-effacing types become very frustrated with resigned types because resigned people just won't engage. Resigned people appreciate the self-effacing person's compulsion to do all the relating in the relationship because it allows them to coast.

If you tell resigned people that you want to change something, they will allow you to make changes in order to avoid conflict but then will resent the changes.

We can learn from resigned people about boundaries, dispassionate observation, and non-judgment.

25. Lastly, what else goes with resignation? (267.3)

An aversion to change.

They have the tools for change but refuse to practice using them and, therefore, don't have the skills to adjust to change. They use their energy to maintain their private fortress. It is very difficult to remodel fortresses.

26. Besides inertia, what two factors enter into this type's attitude toward change? (267.3–268.1)

- A. **They do not expect much from any situation so their incentive to change is small.**
- B. **They are inclined to regard things as unalterable.**

27. When resigned people accept others as unalterable, what are they reflecting? (268.2)

Their view of themselves.

They believe that NO ONE ever changes, including themselves.

Their belief that nothing changes is astonishing. Evidence on every side can prove that change is happening, but they will not acknowledge it because they must believe that nothing and no one changes. They want to maintain their pride in their resigned solution. They also are terrified of going into the not-knowing, of making a move that will expose them to realities that will stir up their conflicts.

28. At first glance we get the impression that the resigned type primarily gives up what? (269.3)

Their ambition.

Resigned types are not interested in exploring their potential but only in finding freedom. They might work hard to get a good retirement and be financially independent, or distract themselves with hobbies they enjoy, but it is not ambitious, neither does it require any curiosity about their hopes or dreams.

29. Which of the expansive trends that may appear in the resigned type interest you? (270.3–271.1)

Open this question to the group.

- **Grandiose fantasies about the great things they could do in their imagination**
- **Feels consciously superior to others and may show this in their behavior**
- **In their feelings about themselves they may tend to be their proud self**
- **They are aware of their claims and are able to assert them effectively**
- **Cherish prestige or are openly rebellious**

One student said: “I believe I can be a great writer just by breathing because I am a great writer, but then I refuse to work on a natural gift because becoming a great writer might impose on my freedom.”

0:40/0:40

30. Which of the self-effacing trends that may appear in the resigned type interest you? (271.3–272.2)

Open this question to the group.

- **Low estimate of themselves**
- **Keenly sensitive to the needs of others**
- **Defenseless towards opposition and attack**
- **Compliant**

The resigned type may look self-effacing from the outside, but they are not motivated by the need to be lovable. They are motivated by the need to avoid any friction and conflict.

Mastery and self-effacing types can eventually wear themselves out and take on resigned characteristics when ambitions are disappointed. However, they will continue to assert their neurotic solution in the areas that success will be most feasible. True resigned types will from the beginning fight for their imagined identity and protect their freedom in the face of perceived imposition. They will not assert anything but will continue their dash for freedom and detachment.

31. How do resigned types try to reach integration? (272.3)

They try to immobilize both expansive and self-effacing drives.

They might latch on to certain philosophies or theologies that will support their need to withdraw from active participation in their own life.

32. On what do resigned people lay an emphasis? (272.4)

They lay an emphasis on being, not on attaining or growing.

They have given up on expressing their real glory in this world and yet continue to believe that they are defending their real self.

Resist initiative, effort, the development of real potential, and alive feelings.

These people will also promote systems that prevent others from self-realization, such as laissez-faire parenting, enabling programs that claim social equity, social service without the need for personal responsibility, give-away ministries based on need only, or entitlements based on race, gender, or sexual orientation.

33. From the viewpoint of resignation, what curtails freedom? (274.1)

Any stronger attachment or any needs.

Actually, they are afraid of consequences and of their own vulnerabilities.

34. What is the obvious flaw in the idea of freedom for this type? (274.3)

Resigned people have done their best to freeze their wishes so they simply do not know what they want.

They want freedom *from*, not freedom *for* a wish or want.

They hate every form of regulation.

A resigned woman started a support group for obesity but would not allow any discussion about what diets or what psychological issues might help or obstruct the process toward health. To avoid being coerced in any way, she had to coerce others. She also undermined any potential progress for herself or others because she was secretly averse to real change.

35. The resigned type's ambivalent way of responding to others is a curious mixture of what? (278.2)

A curious mixture of compliance and defiance.

36. What tendency is reinforced by the strain of associating with others? (279.1)

The tendency to withdraw from others.

Resigned types retreat into stagnation, or disengagement, when life threatens. A recovering resigned neurotic described this tendency to withdraw as "Stagnation Therapy".

37. What results from "silent resistance"? (279.2)

Pervasive inertia.

Resigned neurotics say:

- "One driving force that keeps me going is the conviction that if I don't keep working, things will pile up and I will be under more obligation. Then I am not really living; I'm just enduring. Pushing forward is the alternative to death by pervasive inertia. I am aware that if I stop, I will slide back into it. When I feel the inertia, it is terrifying. I have to do something to kick myself out of it."
- "The mere feeling that I have to do something makes me listless. I go to neurotic envy and resentment when I imagine that others find easy what I feel I have to push through."

38. What is the anxious concern of resigned people? (281.1)

Preserving the integrity of their real self although they are not able to define it.

Their real self is not strong or developed because they won't work on it. They remain weak, which then motivates them to continue defending themselves rather than learning and growing. If they were to work on themselves, they would no longer be able to justify the choices they make to defend their imagined self.

39. What three forms of living in resignation does Dr. Horney identify? (281.2)

- A. **Persistent resignation** – fairly consistent resignation
- B. **Rebellious group** – the appeal of freedom turns passive resistance into more active rebellion
- C. **Shallow living** – e.g., focused on weather, news, sports

Resigned types may need extreme stimulations to feel alive – rescue work, gambling, sexual conquests, gang activities, edgy careers, or just distressing the people around them in order to watch their reactions, etc. These activities serve a dual role: first, the resigned type can vicariously feel something through others by externalizing strong and unconscious feelings; secondly, these activities keep others at a distance.

0:50/0:50 WI

40. What motivates a resigned type to do routine work? (282.1)

Economic necessity, traditional shoulds, and often a need to feel useful to others. Work may be a means of getting away from the feeling of futility.

41. What does pervasive inertia bear within it? (282.3)

The danger of deterioration.

42. Apart from deterioration, what are the dangers of pervasive inertia? (282.3)

The dangers of resistance against doing, thinking, and feeling.

One student said, "I can't want it because I might get it and then I will have to do something about it."

43. What one thing might resigned people want to change? (283.2)

The deadness of their feelings.

Children living under a parent who is emotionally dead take responsibility for the deadness. They imagine that there must be something wrong with them if the parent will not engage with them. The need of the child, alone, will throw a resigned parent into rebelling against that need.

44. Actually, the resigned type is what? (283.3)

A subdued rebel.

45. What becomes more meaningless as resigned people become more alienated from themselves? (285.4)

Freedom.

46. What old truth must the resigned person (and all neurotic types) learn? (281.1; Mark 8:34-38)

We have to lose our neurotic glorified self in order to find our true self.

0:50/0:50 WI

All the groups return to the main group for discussion.

Lead Facilitator might ask:

- Would anyone like to share their overall experience with the book study?
- Does anyone have questions about eligibility for KF or the KF registration process?

- What would you hope to gain if you were to train with Karis Fellowships?

Lead Facilitator: “All students are invited to the KF Introductory Meeting. At this meeting, you will have the opportunity to attend a typical KF meeting in real time and see if KF training is for you. The date, time, and access code for this meeting is on the website. Thank you everyone for showing up and doing this difficult work. It’s been a pleasure to get to know you! We hope to hear your voices at the KF Introductory Meeting. Goodbye everyone.”

1:00/1:00 WI

Dismiss the students and stop the recording. (*9 then 1)

All facilitators, please stay after the meeting to confirm student attendance and homework completion on the [NHG Attendance Spreadsheet](#).

Lead Facilitator: “Are there any comments or questions?”

¹ This reading guide refers to the 1991 edition of *Neurosis and Human Growth: The Struggle Toward Self-Realization* by Karen Horney, published by W.W. Norton and Company Inc. New York.